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Budget relies on new taxes, tweaks

Spending plan includes raising social media, crypto and fantasy sports levies and pausing gas tax hike

By Dan Petrella
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A nearly \$56 billion state spending plan is headed to Gov. JB Pritzker's desk after the Democratic-controlled Illinois legislature approved it in the early-morning hours of another overtime spring session.

The Democratic governor called

the budget package one that would make "people-first investments while maintaining our positive fiscal trajectory and protecting working families from paying new taxes" at a celebratory news conference Monday at the Illinois State Capitol.

The plan doesn't raise the state's sales or income tax rates. But it does rely on a series of new taxes

and tweaks to be balanced, while also reviving some temporary election-year tax breaks Democrats last deployed in 2022, when Pritzker was seeking a second term. Pritzker, who faces voters again in November as he runs for a rare third term, still must sign the package into law.

Here's a look at tax changes it includes for the state budget year that begins July 1.

NEW TAXES

Social media platform fee (Anticipated revenue: \$200 million): The

biggest source of new revenue is a new per-user tax on large social media companies.

Pritzker made the proposal a prominent part of his budget blueprint in February, arguing that social media "companies are profiting from online engagement of Illinois consumers, and they currently contribute nothing to ameliorate the negative effects of their platforms."

Under the plan, beginning Jan. 1, social media platforms with more than 100,000 Illinois users will be

taxed on a graduated per-user scale: 10 cents per month for each user above 100,000; a flat monthly fee of \$40,000 for platforms with more than 500,000 Illinois users plus an additional 25 cents for every user above 500,000; or a flat monthly fee of \$165,000 for platforms with more than 1 million users plus an additional 50 cents for each user above 1 million. Fees would increase annually with the rate of inflation.

Companies would be prohib-

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ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Honor roll student remembered

Eloisa Garcia, left, and Asucena Velazquez, parents of slain Tilden High School honor roll student Pedro Ramírez, hold a banner at the memorial for Ramírez following a march on Thursday. The junior was shot and killed on his way to the school on May 26. Students and staff remembered Ramírez as a leader on his volleyball and soccer teams and in the school's hallways. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

GOP rejects 1st try to kill \$1.8B fund

Proposal's foes plan to force more votes on similar measures

By Mary Clare Jalonick,
Joey Cappelletti
and Kevin Freking
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — Senate Republicans cleared the first hurdle Thursday as they are struggling to pass legislation to fund President Donald Trump's immigration enforcement agencies, narrowly beating back a Democratic effort to permanently block Trump from creating a \$1.776 billion settlement fund for payouts to allies who claim they were persecuted by the government.

Republicans still face a gantlet of Democratic amendments before the bill can advance, setting up a daylong test of party unity. More votes on the settlement fund were planned, including proposals from Republicans, and it was unclear if GOP leaders would be able to fend them all off and pass the legislation.

"I can't predict how it comes out," Senate Majority Leader John Thune told reporters between discussions with some of the hold-outs off the Senate floor.

Senate Minority Leader Chuck Schumer said that Democrats plan to force votes on the tax audit immunity granted to Trump as part of the settlement and a host of other

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Chiquitta Walker and daughter Denym Jenkins, 11, stand outside their home in Chicago on May 26. Walker is upset that the teacher who pushed her daughter in 2024 was reinstated by the Chicago Board of Education. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

In unusual move, teacher accused of pushing student is reinstated

School board rejects CPS recommendation to fire the educator

By Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Third grader Denym Jenkins was meeting with the assistant principal at her Far South Side elementary school two years ago when a teacher walked in and told her to "get out."

The teacher pushed Denym out of the office, slammed the

door behind her and berated the assistant principal, district documents show. Denym was shoved so hard that she nearly fell, and she was later diagnosed with a chronic back strain, her mother told the Tribune.

The following day, the teacher was put on leave pending an investigation. After a monthslong investigation and hearing process, Chicago Public Schools leaders recommended in August 2024 that the school board approve her firing.

But board members rejected

administrators' guidance, voting in February to reinstate the teacher. It was only the second time in at least a decade that the Chicago Board of Education had overruled a termination in a public vote.

The first time was a year earlier, when the same bloc of board members — all of whom are appointed by Mayor Brandon Johnson or aligned with the Chicago Teachers Union — overturned the firing of a school

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OPERATION MIDWAY BLITZ

Judge orders release of man detained outside clinic

Migrant seized while pregnant wife inside Erie Family Health

By Jason Meisner
and Laura Rodríguez Presa
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Eriksen Ventura Romero had just dropped off his pregnant wife at a West Town clinic one morning last October when he found himself surrounded by eight heavily armed Border Patrol agents.

Outside the Erie Family Health Center on West Superior Street, Ventura Romero, a Venezuelan native who was in the midst of immigration proceedings, handed an agent his employment authorization and FaceTimed his wife inside the clinic to warn her their Jeep had been boxed in, federal court records show.

After declaring that Ventura Romero was here illegally, an agent was captured on body-worn camera footage warning they were going to smash his window if he didn't get out of the car. "My wife is there, how can I leave her alone? She does not have anyone else here, it is just me," Ventura Romero pleaded in Spanish, according to court records.

What unfolded over the next 90 seconds was a microcosm of Operation Midway Blitz. The agent smashed the Jeep's window with a baton and Ventura Romero was dragged crying from the car. Bystanders blew whistles and yelled at the agents as they took cellphone video. Ventura Romero struggled a bit, was cuffed behind his back, shocked repeatedly with a Taser and pushed head first into an unmarked government vehicle. Then they drove away.

That was Oct. 24, 2025, some 223 days ago. The full force of Midway Blitz effectively ended in Chicago two weeks later — but not for Ventura Romero. He has spent the next seven months in various jails as his arrest was challenged in court. He was pressured to self-deport and

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INSIDE

Look back when city hosted World Cup

World Cup play returns to the United States this week — 32 years after Chicago experienced the international gathering of nations for the first time. Crowds showed up in force to celebrate the matches that took place at Soldier Field in 1994. **Sports**

Hezbollah rejects latest ceasefire bid

The militant group demanded a complete Israeli withdrawal from Lebanon as more fighting there hampered efforts to end the Iran war. **Nation & World, Page B4**

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